EXECUTIVE EMPLOYMENT & RESTRICTIVE COVENANTS AGREEMENT

Senior Executive Appointment, Equity Incentive & Non-Compete

Effective Date: March 1, 2026

BETWEEN: Sterling Capital Partners LLC ("Company") AND Executive Officer ("Executive")

1. POSITION, DUTIES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

1.1 Executive Role. Company employs Executive as Chief Technology Officer ('CTO'), reporting directly to the Chief Executive Officer and Board of Directors.

1.2 Best Efforts. Executive shall devote full business time, attention, skill, and best efforts to the business and technology operations of the Company.

1.3 Outside Activities. Executive shall not engage in any other business activities or board memberships without the express written consent of the Board.

2. COMPENSATION, ANNUAL BONUS & EQUITY INCENTIVES

2.1 Base Salary. Company shall pay Executive an annual base salary of $325,000, payable in semi-monthly installments in accordance with standard payroll practices.

2.2 Annual Incentive Bonus. Executive shall be eligible for an annual performance bonus with a target of forty percent (40%) of base salary, based on milestones approved by Compensation Committee.

2.3 Long-Term Equity Grant. Executive shall be granted an option to purchase 250,000 Common Units vesting over four (4) years with a one-year cliff.

3. TERMINATION OF EMPLOYMENT & SEVERANCE

3.1 At-Will Employment. Executive's employment is at-will, terminable by either party at any time with or without Cause.

3.2 Termination for Cause. Company may terminate immediately for Cause (fraud, embezzlement, felony conviction, gross willful misconduct). Upon Cause termination, severance is zero.

3.3 Severance Without Cause. If Company terminates Executive without Cause, Executive shall receive twelve (12) months base salary continuation plus subsidized COBRA health benefits for one year.

4. RESTRICTIVE COVENANTS: NON-COMPETITION & NON-SOLICITATION

4.1 Non-Competition. During employment and for twelve (12) months following termination, Executive shall not directly or indirectly manage, advise, or perform services for any competing enterprise.

4.2 Non-Solicitation of Employees. Executive shall not solicit, induce, or hire any employee or contractor of the Company for twelve (12) months post-termination.

4.3 Non-Solicitation of Clients. Executive shall not solicit business from any active client or customer of Company with whom Executive had contact during tenure.

5. INVENTIONS ASSIGNMENT AND CONFIDENTIALITY

5.1 Assignment of Inventions. All patents, algorithms, models, and intellectual property developed by Executive during employment relating to Company business are the exclusive property of Company.

5.2 Confidentiality. Executive shall hold all proprietary trading strategies, client lists, and software systems in strict confidence during and perpetually after employment.

6. GOVERNING LAW AND ARBITRATION

6.1 Governing Law. This Agreement shall be governed by and interpreted under the laws of the State of Delaware.

6.2 Mandatory Arbitration. Any controversy arising out of this Agreement shall be settled by binding arbitration before JAMS in Wilmington, Delaware under its Employment Arbitration Rules.

IN WITNESS WHEREOF, the parties have executed this Agreement as of the Effective Date.

Authorized Representative
Date: October 1, 2025

Authorized Representative
Date: October 1, 2025